

Let's try to lay out Sider's reasoning by isolating the various features of the **traditional doctrine** of heaven and hell that he thinks are inconsistent with the existence of a perfectly good God.

“A certain traditional conception of the afterlife is *binary*. After death one proceeds either to heaven or hell. Heaven is very, very good; hell is very, very bad. There are no possibilities for the afterlife other than heaven and hell, and membership in heaven or hell is never indeterminate or a matter of degree. The problem with the binary conception is that it contradicts God's justice. God must employ some criterion to decide who goes to heaven and who goes to hell. No reasonable criterion would be sharp; any reasonable criterion will have borderline cases. But the binary conception of the afterlife allows for no corresponding fuzziness in how the dead are to be treated. Hell must therefore contain people who are nearly indiscernible in relevant respects from people in Heaven. No just God would allow such a monstrously unfair thing.”

It is part of the traditional doctrine that God decides whether people go to heaven and hell based on certain properties of those people. We will leave open for now what those properties might be; just to have a name for them, let's call them the **relevant properties**.

Badness

Dichotomy

Non-
universality

Divine
control

Justice

Proportion- ality

Continuity

If you are a theist interested in defending the possibility of an afterlife, you have two options.

First, you might reject one of the theses claimed to be part of the traditional doctrine.

Second, you might reject one of the two additional theses used to argue against the traditional doctrine.

It seems difficult to deny Justice, Badness, or Divine Control. So that
seems to give the defender of the afterlife four main options.



the
paradox of
heaven and
hell



replies to the
paradox

A solid red circle with a subtle drop shadow, containing white text.

evil & lives
not worth
living

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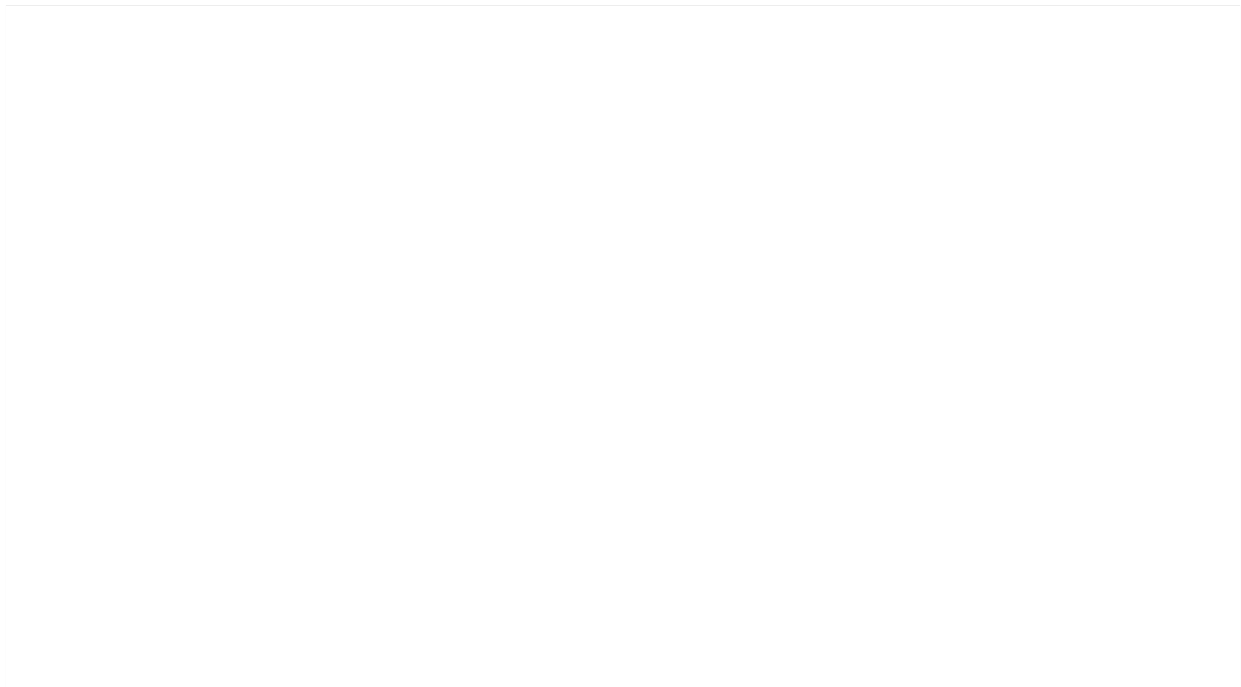


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The following passage from the Catechism of the Catholic Church

describes the kind of view wanted to discuss:



Judgment. Christ will come "in his glory, and all

1038. The resurrection of all the dead, 'of both the

just and the unjust,' will precede the Last

eternity!

the angels with him... Before him will be gathered

goats, and he will place the sheep at his right hand,

another as a shepherd separates the sheep from the

all the nations, and he will separate them one from

but the goats at the left.... and they will go away

into external punishment, but the rights into

One topic often associated with belief in God is the topic of life after death.

Our first question today is: what we are told about life after death by

many of the major monotheistic religions compatible with the existence of a

perfectly good Good?



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1038. The reservation of the dead, "of

talk of the last judgment wouldn't make much sense.)

This certainly seems like a picture according to which, after death, God passes

got to heaven forever, and some to hell forever. (If not 'forever', then the

judgment on all of us, and on the basis of our life, decides that some of us will

view of life after death we get here on pain of being perfectly good?

Turned-in showed why it is plausible that respo to the argument from evil

must depend on the possibility of life after death. We will now ask: is the kind of



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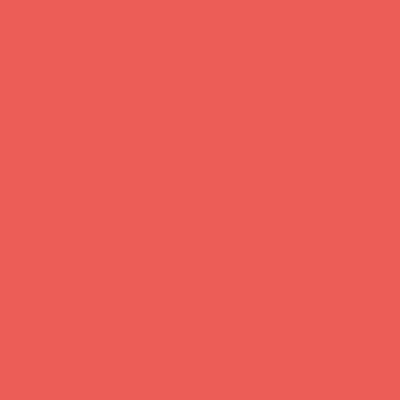


replies to the
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evil & lives
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Badness



Divine
control

Justice



the 1990s, the number of people in the UK who are employed in the public sector has increased by 1.5 million, from 2.5 million in 1980 to 4 million in 1999. The public sector has grown from 10% of the economy to 17% of the economy.

There is a growing concern that the public sector is becoming too large and too expensive. The public sector is now the largest employer in the UK, and it is the largest consumer of public funds. The public sector is also the largest provider of public services, and it is the largest provider of public goods.

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